



Red Signals

■ Some CPI(M) leaders hope for a repeat of the United Front government experiment in 1996 when the Left held sway.

■ The BSP wants a handful of seats in Kerala and West Bengal which the Left parties are loath to give up.

■ If Karat's attempts to cobble up a third alternative fall flat, he will face a tough time in the party.

■ In open defiance of the central leaders, CPI(M)'s West Bengal unit wants Somnath Chatterjee back in the party fold.

TOP CPI(M) LEADERS PRIVATELY AGREE THAT THE LEFT WILL NOT REGAIN ITS 2004 HEIGHTS

"There will be no alliance with the BSP in Left states."

D. RAJA
CPI

parties led by the Left with outside support from the Congress, if necessary.

At the Kochi meeting, senior leaders debated endlessly about the post-poll relationship with the Congress. There was a tacit admission that the bonhomie of 2004 would be missing. Hence the party's anxiety to stitch as many alliances as possible at the regional level to make up for its own likely deficit in terms of seats. Ideological hang-ups are not to cause the Left any hurdle in this pursuit. Yechury said the CPI(M) had already arrived at poll understandings in all the southern states. "We have an understanding with the AIADMK in Tamil Nadu, Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in Andhra Pradesh and Janata Dal (Secular) in Karnataka," said Yechury.

But it is the big catch that is play-

ing hookey. "There will be no electoral understanding with the BSP. But we consider them to be part of the non-BJP, non-Congress camp and they have assured us that they will be part of the campaign on issues of common interest," said Karat. The gusto of the Coimbatore party congress which ratified Karat's proposal for a credible third alternative is now a thing of the past. Karat was so upbeat then that he had even described Mayawati as prime minister material. But a few months down the line, when he deputed TDP leader N. Chandrababu Naidu to initiate seat-sharing talks, Mayawati politely showed them the door. The BSP chief made a clever move much in advance by saying that her party would contest all the 80 seats in Uttar Pradesh and would back off only

if the CPI(M) earmarks a few seats in Kerala and West Bengal. The hopes that Mayawati would realise her limits in the light of the reverses in recent elections have been belied.

If Karat's attempts to cobble up a third alternative fall flat, he will face a tough time within the party. The Kochi meet coincided with the embarrassing news from West Bengal where the leadership faced the wrath of the electorate over Nandigram and the party surrendered the seat to Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress. The first sign of defiance is coming from the powerful state unit with a proposal to reinstate beleaguered Speaker Somnath Chatterjee. CPI(M) leader and state Sports and Youth Affairs Minister Subhas Chakraborty has shot off a confidential letter to state Secretary Biman Bose hailing Chatterjee's indispensability in national politics. With the CPI(M) facing an onslaught in its own backyard, it is a concession that the party can hardly afford to make.

with Shafi Rahman